Fences

By August Wilson

BONO: **(Pg 59)** Some people build fences to keep people out . . . and other people build fences to keep people in . . .

INTRODUCTION

According to Life Coach Elisabetta Franzoso: our ability to sustain satisfying and committed relationships, find gratification in our work, be effective parents, and our ability to speak up and assert ourselves are largely dependent on the relationship we have or had with our fathers. When that relationship is toxic, the cycle of damage is carried on from generation to generation.

In Fences by August Wilson, the sins of the father are visited upon the son. Troy Maxson's damaging relationship with his father comes barreling down to impact the relationship Troy has with his own son.

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TROY: **(Pg 49-50)** *(to the audience – he has a bat in his hands and occasionally takes a swing at an imagined pitch)* Sometime I wish I hadn't known my daddy. He ain't cared nothing about no kids. A kid to him wasn't nothing. All he wanted was for you to learn how to walk so he could start you to working. When it come time for eating . . . he ate first. If there was anything left over, that's what you got. Man would sit down and eat two chickens and give you the wing.

The only thing my daddy cared about was getting them bales of cotton in to Mr. Lubin. That's the only thing that mattered to him. Sometimes I used to wonder why he was living. Wonder why the devil hadn't come and got him. "Get them bales of cotton in to Mr. Lubin" and fine out he owe him money . . .

But I'll say this for him . . . he felt a responsibility toward us. Maybe he ain't treated us the way I felt he should have . . . but without that responsibility he could have walked off and left us . . . made his own way. *(pause, considering)* How he gonna leave with eleven kids? And

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where he gonna go? He aint knew how to do nothing but farm. No, he was trapped and I think he knew it.

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TROY: **(Pg 33)** *(calling)* Cory! Get your butt out here, boy! *(Cory (17) enters)* You just now coming in here from leaving this morning?

CORY: Yeah, I had to go to football practice.

TROY: Yeah, what?

CROY: Yessir.

TROY: I ain't but two seconds off you noway. The garbage sitting in there overflowing . . you ain't done none of your chores . . . and you come in here talking about "Yeah" *(pause)* **(Pg 37)** Your mama tell me you done got recruited by a college football team? Is that right?

CORY: Yeah. Coach Zellman say the recruiter gonna be coming by to talk to you. Get you to sign the permission paper.

TROY: **(Pg 36)** Colored guy got to be twice as good before he get on the team. I don't want you to get all tied up in them sports. **(Pg 37)** I thought you supposed to be working down there at the A&P. You suppose to keep up with your chores and hold that job down.

CORY: Mr. Stawicki say he gonna hold my job for me until after the football season. Starting next week I can work weekends.

TROY: You damn right you are! And ain't no need for nobody coming around here to talk to me about signing nothing.

CORY: Hey, Pop . . . you can't do that. He's coming all the way from North Carolina.

TROY: I don't care where he coming from. The white man ain't gonna let you get nowhere with that football noway. You go on and work yourself up in that A&P or learn how to fix cars or build houses or something, get you a trade.

CORY: I get good grades, Pop. That's why the recruiter wants to talk with you. You got to keep up your grades to get recruited. I'll be going to college.

TROY: **(Pg 38)** You a bigger fool than I thought. Let somebody take away your job so you can play football. I'm the boss . . . you understand? *(tense beat –gets in Cory's face)* I asked you

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. . . did you understand? *(Cory is silent)* You go on down there to that A& P and see if you can get your job back. You quit the football team. *(turns and starts to walk away)*

CORY: *(pause)* How come you ain't never liked me?

TROY: Liked you? Who the hell say I got to like you? *(pause)* **(Pg 39)** You eat every day. Got a roof over your head. Got clothes on your back. Why you think that is?

CORY: Cause of you? *(hesitant)* Cause you like me?

TROY: Like you? You about the biggest fool I ever say. *(pause)* **(Pg 40)** Not cause I like you! Cause it's my duty to take care of you. Let's get this straight right here . . . I ain't got to like you. Mr. Rand don't give me my money come payday cause he likes me. He gives me cause he owe me. I done give you everything I had to give you. I gave you your life! And liking your ass wasn't part of the bargain. Don't go through life worrying about if somebody like you or not. You understand what I'm saying, boy? Get the hell out of my face, and get on down to that A&P.

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TROY: **(Pg 50-51)** *(to the audience – he has a bat in his hands and occasionally takes a swing at an imagined pitch)* My daddy stayed right there with his family. But he was just as evil as he could be. My mama couldn't stand him. Couldn't stand that evilness. She run off when I was about eight. She sneaked off one night after he had gone to sleep. Told me she was coming back for me. I ain't never seen her no more. All his women run off and left him. He wasn't good for nobody. When my turn come to head out, I was fourteen and had us an old mule we called Greyboy. My daddy sent me out to do some plowing and I tied up Greyboy and went to fooling around with Joe Canewell's daughter. She about thirteen and we done figured we was grown anyway . . . so we down there enjoying ourselves . . . ain't thinking about nothing. We didn't know Greyboy had got loose and wandered back to the house and my daddy was looking for me.

My daddy come up on us. Surprised us. He had them leather straps off the mule and commenced to whupping me like there was no tomorrow. I jumped up, mad and embarrassed. I was scared of my daddy.

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CORY: **(Pg 79)** I ain't scared of you! You don't count around here no more.

TROY: I don't count around here no more. All of a sudden you done got so grown that your daddy don't count around here no more. **(Pg 80)** You gonna wear my pants? I done spent the last seventeen years worrying about what you got. Now it's your turn, see? You grown. . . You a man. Now let's see you act like one. *(pushes Cory's chest hard)* Turn your behind around and walk out this yard. And when you get out there in the alley . . . you can forget about this house. See? Cause this is my house.

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TROY: **(Pg 51)** *(to the audience – he has a bat in his hands and occasionally takes a swing at an imagined pitch)* When he commenced to whupping on me . . . I run to get out of the way *(pause)* I thought he was mad cause I ain't done my work. But I see where he was chasing me off so he could have the gal for himself.

When I see what the matter of it was, I lost all fear of my daddy. Right there is where I become a man. . . at fourteen years of age. *(Pause)* Now it was my turn to run him off. *(he beats the ground with the bat)* I picked up them same reins that he had used on me and commenced to whupping on him. The gal jumped up and run off . . . and when my daddy turned to face me, I could see why the devil had never come to get him . . . cause he was the devil himself.

CORY: **(Pg 38)** *(echoing in Troy's mind)* How come you ain't never liked me?

TROY: **(Pg 51)** I don't know what happened. When I woke up, I was laying right there by the creek. I thought I was blind. I couldn't see nothing. Both my eyes were swollen shut. I layed there and cried. I didn't know what I was gonna do. The only thing I knew was the time had come for me to leave my daddy's house.

(Pg 52) I got up from the creek and walked on down to Mobile. I was through with farming. Figured I could do better in the city. So I walked the two hundred miles to Mobile. They ain't had no cars and things like they go now. We talking about 1918.

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(Pg 53) I walked on down to Mobile and hitched up with some of them fellows that was heading this way. Got up here and found out . . . not only couldn't you get a job . . . you couldn't find no place to live.

TROY: **(Pg 37)** *(echoing his words to Cory)* You suppose to keep up with your chores and hold that job down.

TROY: **(Pg 53)** I thought I was in freedom. Shhh. Colored folks living down there on the riverbanks in whatever kind of shelter they could find for themselves. Right down there under the Brady Street Bridge. Living in shacks made of sticks and tar paper. Went from bad to worse. Started stealing. First it was food. Then I figured, hell, if I steal money I can buy me some food. Buy me some shoes too! One thing led to another.

Went out one day looking for somebody to rob . . . that's what I was, a robber. I'll tell you the truth. I'm ashamed of it today. But it's the truth. Went to rob this fellow . . . pulled out my knife . . . and he pulled out a gun. Shot me in the chest. It felt just like somebody had taken a hot branding iron and laid it on me. When he shot me I jumped at him with my knife. They told me I killed him and they put me in the penitentiary and locked me up for fifteen years. That's where I learned to play baseball. *(takes a swing)*

(Pg 14) What [baseball] ever get me? Ain't got a pot to piss in or a window to throw it out of. *(softly)* **(Pg 15)** If you could play ball then they ought to have let you play. Don't care what color you were. If you could play . . . then they ought to have let you play. *(echoing of words he had with Cory)* **(Pg 36)** Colored guy got to be twice as good before he get on the team. I don't want you to get all tied up in them sports.

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CORY: **(Pg 55-56)** *(storms in, angry and confrontational)* What you do that for, Pop? Went up to the school and told Coach Zellman I can't play football no more. Told him to tell the recruiter not to come.

TROY: *(threateningly)* Yeah, I did it. And [you] know why I did it. *(pause)* Lied to me! Wanna play football . . . keep up [your] chores and hold down that job at the A& P. That was the conditions.

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CORY: **(Pg 80-81)** You ain't never done nothing but hold me back. Afraid I was gonna be better than you. All you ever did was try and make me scared of you. I used to tremble every time you called my name. Every time I heard your footsteps in the house. What's Papa gonna say if I do this? . . . What's he gonna say if I do that? What you gonna do . . . give me a whupping? You're too old. You just an old man!

TROY: Get your ass out of my yard! *(Cory grabs up Troy's bat from where it always lays)*

CORY: I ain't going nowhere. I ain't scared of you. *(swings the bat at Troy who steps back, then advances)* Come on! Come on!

TROY: **(Pg 82)** You wanna draw that bat back on me . . .you're gonna have to use it *(Cory swings the bat a second time and misses)* You're gonna have to kill me! *(grabs the bat and the struggle. Ultimately Troy is stronger and takes the bat from Cory. Cory crouches in a protective position. Troy stands over him ready to swing. He stops himself)* Go on and get away from my house. *(Cory, stung by his defeat exits slowly)*

(Troy walks about the yard. A quiet rage threatens to consume him. He tries desperately to calm himself. He clutches his heart, wipes sweat from his face and rubs his arm - He is clearly having a heart attack)

(Pg 72-73) All right Mr. Death. See now . . . I'm gonna take and build me a fence around this year. See? I'm gonna build me a fence around what belong to me. And then I want you to stay on the other side.

BONO: **(Pg 59)** Some people build fences to keep people out . . . and other people build fences to keep people in

TROY: **(Pg 73)** You ain't gonna sneak up on me no more. Ain't nobody else got nothing to do with this. This is between you and me. Man to man. You say on the other side of that fence until you ready for me. Then bring your army. Bring your sickle. When the top of your list say Troy Maxson *(swings the bat feebly)* Come on! Come on! I be ready for you . . . but I ain't gonna be easy! *(falls and the light and rage leave him)*

CORY: **(Pg 89)** *(rnters and finds his father dead on the ground; his bat still in his hands. He grieves silently for a moment then speaks slowly to the audience)* The whole time I was growing up. . . Papa was like a shadow that followed you everywhere. It weighed on you and

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sunk into your flesh. It would wrap around you and lay there until you couldn't tell which one was you anymore. Everywhere I looked, Troy Maxson was staring back at me. *(reaches out to close Troy's eyes)* **(Pg 90)** I don't want to be Troy Maxson . . . I want to be me.

NOTE: A video clip of a scene from this play showing 2 different characterizations for Troy Maxson (James Earl Jones vs Denzel Washington) can be found here: https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=jE2dDmMGfa4

SOURCE INFORMATION

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AWARD HISTORY

2002 National Qualifier
2003 National Qualifier
2005 National Qualifier
2006 National Qualifier
2013 National Qualifier
MN State Qualifier
OH State Qualifier

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